

Afghanistan



The world's poorest state, gripped by armed conflict, Islamic fundamentalism, and civil war since 1979.

530S BCE **Cyrus the Great** makes Afghanistan part of the Persian Empire.

327 BCE **Alexander the Great** conquers most of the Afghan satrapies.

50 CE **Afghanistan becomes** part of the Kushan Empire.

250 **Afghanistan becomes** part of the Persian Sassanian Empire.

652 **Arab armies invade**, bringing Islam with them.

820s **Local Arab or** Persian families rule most of the country.

997 **Mahmud of Ghazni** extends his power as far as the Punjab in India.

1219 **Genghis Khan invades**.

1369 **Timur** (Tamerlane) invades and makes the country part of his empire.

1504 **Babur, a descendant** of Genghis Khan and Timur, makes Kabul the capital of an independent principality and goes on to establish the Mughal Empire in northern India.

1530 **On the death of Babur**, Afghanistan is divided between an Uzbek north, Mughal east, and Persian west.

1747 **Ahmed Shah Durrani**, a Pashtun leader, is elected emir by the tribal council and establishes the last great independent Afghan Empire.

1809 **Afghanistan signs** a treaty of friendship with Britain in which the Afghan ruler Shah Shuja promises to oppose the passage of foreign (Russian) troops through his territory.

1823 **After the death of the** last Durrani emir, no new ruler emerges until 1826, when Dost Muhammad becomes emir. During his reign, the UK and Russia begin to compete for influence in the region during the so-called "Great Game."

1839–42 **Following the failure** of a British mission to Kabul led by Captain Alexander Burnes in 1837, British forces invade Afghanistan during the first Anglo-Afghan war in an attempt to overthrow Dost Muhammad. He is at first deposed but restored after a major Afghan revolt in Kabul, the capital.

1855 **Dost Muhammad** signs treaty of friendship with the UK.

1878–81 **The second Anglo-Afghan** war follows British failure to establish full control over Afghanistan's foreign relations, after the Afghan ruler grants territory to Russia.

1879 **Under the Treaty** of Gandamak signed with Emir Yaqub Ali Khan, various Afghan areas are annexed by the UK. Yaqub Ali Khan is later exiled and a new treaty is signed in 1893 with Emir Abdul Rahman, establishing the Durand Line, a contentious boundary between Afghanistan and British India that splits Pashtun lands in two.

1895 **The UK and Russia** create the "Afghan Finger," or Wakhan Corridor, a sliver of land that stretches through the Pamir Mountains to China, which they attach to Afghanistan, thus keeping the rival British and Russian empires apart.

1901 **Habibullah** becomes emir.

1904 **The western border** with Persia is finally settled.

1907 **The Anglo-Russian Entente** guarantees Afghanistan's independence with British control of its foreign affairs.

1919 **Habibullah is assassinated**; his successor, Amunallah, attempts to free his country from British influence and invades India. A third, brief Afghan War breaks out that ends when the British bomb Kabul and Jalalabad. By the Treaty of Rawalpindi, the British recognize Afghanistan's full independence.

1928 **Amanullah** begins to reform the country, reducing the power of religious leaders and giving women more freedom, banning the veil and ending polygamy; he now styles himself king.

1929 **Amanullah abdicates** as a revolt breaks out against his reforms; he is replaced by an illiterate Tajik warlord, Bacha-i Saqao, who seizes the throne. Later that year, Amanullah's cousin, Nadir Khan, seizes power and becomes king.

1932 **The country's first** university is founded in Kabul.

1933 **Nadir Khan is assassinated**; his son, Zahir Shah, becomes king.



Ill-fated Afghan adventures

British troops are seen here mobilizing in Kabul during the second Afghan War of 1878–81. Britain fought three wars in Afghanistan to protect British India and keep the Russians at bay but failed to subdue the rebellious Afghans.

“We will not accept a government of **wrong-doers. We prefer death than to be part of an **evil government**.”**

MULLAH OMAR, TALIBAN LEADER, AFTER HIS DEFEAT, 2001

1946 **Afghanistan** joins the UN.

1953 **Mohammad Daud Khan** is named prime minister.

1956 **First Five-Year Plan** to modernize the country with Soviet aid as Daud Khan becomes increasingly pro-Soviet.

1963 **Daud resigns** after the king rejects his proposals for democratic reforms.

1964 **King Zahir Shah** introduces limited democratic reforms as he attempts to become a constitutional monarch.

1965 **Elections are held**, but the monarchy retains power. The Marxist Party of Afghanistan (PDPA) is formed and banned. PDPA splits into the Parcham (flag) and Khalq (masses) factions.

1973 **Daud mounts a** coup with Parcham support, and declares a republic. The Mujahideen rebellion begins.

1978 **Mohammad Taraki** takes power and introduces communist rule.

1979 **Taraki is ousted** by the hardline Hafizullah Amin. Amin is then killed in a coup backed by the USSR that sends in 80,000 troops to support the new moderate Parcham PDPA government of Babrak Karmal. The Mujahideen rebellion is stepped up into full-scale guerrilla war with US backing.

1986 **Muhammad Najibullah** replaces Karmal as head of government.

1988 **Peace accord with USSR**.

1989 **Last Soviet troops** withdraw.

1992 **Najibullah overthrown** by the Mujahideen, but civil war soon erupts between the different groups.

1994 **The radical Islamist Taliban** movement captures Kandahar and makes it its stronghold. Osama bin Laden returns to the country to set up Al-Qaeda bases.

1996 **Taliban seizes Kabul** and impose strict Islamic regime; the Northern Alliance leads resistance to the Taliban.

1998 **Earthquake in north** kills thousands.

2000 **Country suffers worst** drought in 30 years. The UN imposes sanctions in response to Taliban support for bin Laden.

2001 **Ancient Buddhist** statues in Bamiyan destroyed.

2001 **Following the 9/11 attacks** in New York, US-led coalition forces attack Afghanistan in a concerted effort to flush out Al-Qaeda terrorists and bring down the Taliban government. Hamid Karzai heads new coalition government. US and other foreign troops occupy the country.

2004 **The Loya Jirga** (Grand Council) of tribal leaders establishes a new constitution. Hamid Karzai wins presidential election.

2005 **The Taliban regroup**s and goes on the offensive, exploiting popular resentment at foreign occupation.

2006 **NATO takes over** responsibility for security across the whole of Afghanistan.

2007 **A series of offensives** in Helmand province takes place, aimed at dislodging the Taliban. The opium crop is reported to be at an all-time high.

2008 **Germany, France, and Britain** increase troop numbers. A bomb attack on the Indian embassy in Kabul kills 50.

2009 **A major US offensive** in Helmand takes place. Hamid Karzai is reelected president amidst allegations of ballot rigging. President Obama announces plans to increase US troop levels by 30,000.

2010 **Further NATO offensives** take place in Helmand.

«78–79 **Bronze Age Collapse**

«174–77 **The Ascent of Islam**

«444–45 **War in Afghanistan**